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Mahatma Gandhi in Europe (1931)

DRESSED in loin-cloth and sandals and with but a shawl to protect him from the inclement weather, the Mahatma landed in Marseilles on September 11th, 1931. A select group of British and Indian friends and admirers met him there and accompanied him to London. On arriving there, he was taken straight to a reception at the Friends' House. In reply to the address of welcome, referring to the British Government, he humorously remarked: 'You cannot honestly balance the Budget without first balancing the relations between India and England.'

The writer was one of those who at one time felt misgivings as to whether the Mahatma would be well-advised to visit Europe in his characteristic loin-cloth. On his former visits to Europe, he was, of course, clothed differently. But on this occasion he did the right thing in adhering to his favourite dress Questioned by a reporter about his dress, the Mahatma once jocosely remarked : 'You people wear plus-fours, mine are minus-fours.' Then changing to a more serious vein, he said : 'If I came here to live and work like an English citizen, then I should conform to the customs of the country and should wear the dress of an Englishman. But I am here on a great and special mission, and my loin-cloth, if you choose so to describe it, is the dress of my principals, the people of India.' His countrymen today feel proud that he stuck to the dress of his principals and even attended the Buckingham Palace party in the same dress.

During his stay in London, between September 12th and December 1st, the Mahatma spoke twelve times at the Round Table Conference[1]—twice before the plenary session of the Con-

[1] The second Round Table Conference consisted of 107 members Of these, 65 were from British India, 22 from the Indian States and 20 from the three British Parties The Minorities Committee of the Conference was composed of 6 Britishers 13 Moslems 10 Hindus 2 from